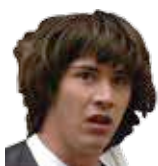


of transformation or manipulation of a base idea before it is spread - even if the manipulation is nothing more than the addition of one's opinion to the idea (Case in point - almost no two meme images that you see online are the same, even if they are based on the exact same meme). Genes mostly replicate unaltered, with a modification or mutation creeping in as a rarity. Memes mutate more frequently. It makes more sense to understand that like the process of evolution with genes, memes actually mutate in majority, and in this mutation lies the key to an evolved, persistent 'fit' meme that survives.

While showing why a meme is mostly like a gene is a step in the right direction, it doesn't get you all the way. A similarity between memes and viruses lies in the way that it behaves with you - the individual, the consumer, the reader. A typical parasite needs a conducive medium to spread - you usually do not catch a cold in the middle of the summer or contract a deadly virus in a squeaky clean locality. And never before has there been a more suitable environment for the spread of ideas than the internet. But even before that, ideas always had their own ways of getting spread around - be it through libraries, public gatherings, entertainment media and more.

A typical virus enters your body, reacts with it, attacks it or alters it, and either gets rejected and quarantined or accepted and forwarded. Just like that, an idea, once it reaches the end point of your mind, either persists there or gets dismissed. In the case of the former, you become the host to that idea, comprehending and interpreting it, in turn changing your own understanding of it. In the end, it is you, the host, that is affected by the idea while the idea still lies out there in its initial 'unaffected-by-you' form and also in your own variation of it, in either case looking at being spread further - as Daniel Dennett wonderfully said, "a scholar is a library's way of making another library".



THE UNKNOWN THREADS?

We cannot get away with establishing that a meme is like a

virus and then not explaining how it can behave. Since, undoubtedly, there are specific, underlying rules that govern it and, in turn, you. While not exhaustive, there are some maxims that have been identified which shed some light on this - collectively sometimes referred to as the rules of the internet. Memes create stereotypes, stereotypes create the memes and so on it goes. Just like genes, it is not possible to comprehend the characteristics of a meme in isolation. Genes usually have phenotypic effects in the presence of other genes. Similarly memes spread in the presence of certain favorable behaviour patterns. And to understand these patterns, one needs to look at the underlying rules mentioned earlier. Keep in mind though, that these rules represent a small part of a much larger system of maxims constantly being modified and updated to reach absolute ideas, so what appears funny to you today, might be a grave and serious truth tomorrow. But for today, these memes inform you of numerous stereotypes and go on to point out how they ideally behave. For instance:

- 'Forever alone' is an ironically sad person and if you behave a certain way/do a certain thing, you're one;
- Trolling is humor, and you're kind of an uptight jerk if you take it seriously and more;

Don't get us wrong - stereotypes have always existed. But things work a bit differently when they are spread on the internet. Urban legends have always been a meme, but they are now spread to way more people with access to the internet and receive much more credibility thanks to technology aiding false evidence. For example, Slenderman was a fictional creature created for an online contest in 2009, the mythos of which was further expanded in the years to come. After reading a creepypasta (which itself is simply 'creepy' stories copied and 'pasted' all over the internet) about him, two 12 year olds in Waukesha, Wisconsin stabbed a third one 19 times to appease the fictional creature and keep their families safe from him. The girl barely survived and the trial

is still ongoing. And this was a faceless man who had tentacles coming out of his back.

If you're pondering on why they would do that, the 1% rule of the internet in combination with Poe's law (both being part of the maxims that were referred to earlier, mentioned in separate box) makes it much easier to understand that a fake idea, no matter how outrageous it might be, if presented well on the internet (i.e without the obvious disclaimers that Poe's law specifies) might just be perceived as gospel truth. If you use a meme to describe a person repeatedly, at one point of time there will be people who would have formed that opinion about that very person, without verification. But you don't have to reach out to a lesser known case to see this in action.



WHAT IF I TOLD YOU THAT IT ACTUALLY WORKS?

We've all heard the statement 'Don't feed the trolls', or one of its modifications (once again, a meme) and have generally accepted it as the right course of action against the spreading of obvious misinformation or plainly stupid arguments - for example, comparison to Nazis as outlined in Godwin's law. But this has led to a very interesting phenomenon that has impacted one of the most important



Without memes, there might have been a completely different person in the oval office right now